Whose Job Is It to Make Disciples?

When Jesus commanded, "Go . . . make disciples" (Matt. 28:19), to whom was He speaking? Ellen White clarifies:

"The Saviour's commission to the disciples included **all the believers**. . . . Whatever one's calling in life, his first interest should be to win souls for Christ. He may not be able to speak to congregations, but he can work for **individuals**" (*The Desire of Ages*, p. 822).

"Let ministers teach church members that in order to grow in spirituality, they must carry the burden that the Lord has laid upon them—the burden of **leading souls into the truth**" (*Christian Service*, p. 69).

The command to go and make disciples was given to all believers. Amid all our busy activities in the church, we must never forget that we were called to focus on people, not just programs, and to lead souls into the truth. And when we do, we will grow spiritually! The most important work of the church is not big events, though these are beneficial. Rather, it's the individual soul-winning efforts of church members.

"One soul, won to the truth, will be instrumental in winning others, and there will be an ever-increasing result of blessing and salvation. Your work may accomplish more real good than the more extensive meetings, if they lack in **personal effort**. When both are combined, with the blessing of God, a more perfect and thorough work may be wrought; but if we can have but one part done, let it be the **individual labor** of opening the Scriptures in households" (*Christian Service*, p. 121).

Jesus instructed us to "preach the gospel to every creature" (Mark 16:15), but this can never be accomplished merely by pastors preaching from pulpits. It will require much personal labor by dedicated church members. Such was the case in the early church when laypeople, who were scattered by persecution, "went everywhere preaching the word" (Acts 8:4). Biblical "preaching" was often fulfilled in personal settings (see Acts 8:35). Jesus Himself was the Master of this approach (see John 3:1-31; 4:7-26).

"Christ's method alone will give true success in reaching the people. . . . There is need of coming close to the people by **personal effort**" (*The Ministry of Healing*, p. 143).

"The Lord desires that His word of grace shall be brought home to every soul. To a great degree this must be accomplished by **personal labor**. This was **Christ's method**" (*Christian Service*, p. 117).

Christ's method of making disciples is something every church member can do. It's about coming close to people individually—befriending them, patiently guiding them into Bible truth, and being an ongoing friend and mentor to them. The good news is that when we accept the call to "make disciples" (Matt. 28:19), we can claim the promise of Jesus: "I am with you always" (Matt. 28:20).